2. Comparing the countries

Research date: 17 August 2026. Target intake: autumn 2027.

The one-page version

Country	Tuition (non-EU)	Language for you	146 issue	Post-study stay	Verdict
Austria (the right FH)	**€727/yr**	English	**Not counted at all**	12 mo -> Red-White-Red Card	**Top pick**
France	€4,055/yr	French, native	Fine ("Bac+3")	12 mo APS	**Top pick**
Italy	**€157–1,000/yr** with ISEE	English or Italian	Fine ("three years")	~12 mo	**Top pick**
Spain	**~€1,300 total**	Spanish (Tier B)	Fine ("3 years")	24 mo, but **no work rights**	Strong, later
Ireland	€11,000–14,000/yr	English	Borderline (wants Level 8)	**24 mo, full work rights**	Strong
Belgium	€5,369/yr	French, native	Bridging route exists	12 mo, full work rights	Strong
Portugal	€4,000–7,500/yr	English or Portuguese	Fine	Yes	Good
Poland	~€2,500–7,500 total	English (B2 now required)	Fine	9 mo	Good
Czechia	€2,700/yr (or €0 in Czech)	English or Czech (Tier C)	Fine	9 mo, full access	Fair
Hungary	**€0 + stipend** if funded	English	Unverified	Unverified	Worth one application
UK	£11,800–23,000/yr	English	**Doesn't exist**	**18 mo** from Jan 2027	Three schools only
Germany	~€0–1,500	German (Tier C)	**Blocked** — and GPA too	18 mo	Deprioritise
Denmark (Aalborg)	€7,450/yr, ~15 full awards	English	**Free binding assessment**	3 yrs, but 90 hrs/mo	Strong
Norway (UiA)	**€5,385/yr**	English	**Fine — assessed by years**	Varies	Reopened
Finland	€7,000–10,000/yr net	English	Fine	**2 yrs, any sector — best**	Costlier now
Sweden	High	English	Fine	Yes	Funding closed
Netherlands	—	English	**Depends on your diploma**	—	See below
Switzerland	—	—	**Blocked**	—	Closed

The three that stand out

Austria — the surprise, and probably your best single option

Austria was not even on our original shortlist. Two separate researchers landed on it independently, for different reasons.

Why it works for you specifically. Austrian *Fachhochschulen* (universities of applied sciences) are governed by a law — *Fachhochschul-Gesetz* §4(4) — that defines master's entry as completing a relevant bachelor's **or an equivalent programme at a recognised foreign institution**. There is **no 180-credit count anywhere in that text**. It goes further: a programme director may admit someone whose equivalence is only partial and settle the difference through exams **taken during the master's**.

The only number FH Kufstein publishes is *"at least 30 ECTS"* in marketing, communication, management or business subjects. A Licence in Marketing clears that several times over.

And the rest lines up:

- **€363.36 per semester — €726.72 per year** at FH Kufstein, and that is the rate *everyone* pays, third-country nationals included. (Add the ÖH student union fee of about €25/semester.)
- Taught **100% in English**.
- Post-study: **12-month job-search permit**, then a **Red-White-Red Card with no points test and no labour-market test**. For someone with a modest GPA, an immigration route that does not score you is worth a great deal.
- Deadline for non-EU applicants: **3 March**.

But you must pick the right Austrian institution — the spread is enormous

This is the thing to understand about Austria, and it isn't obvious:

Austrian applied-sciences institutions each set their own third-country fee policy. The range across the sector is roughly **23-fold**:

Institution	Per semester
FH Kufstein, FH Salzburg, FH des BFI Wien, CAMPUS 02	**€363.36**
FH Kärnten	€500
FH Oberösterreich, FH Joanneum	€726.72
FH Wiener Neustadt	€850
FH Technikum Wien	€3,000
IMC Krems	€6,900
MCI Innsbruck	**€8,250** (~€16,500/year)

Austrian public universities are a different and worse proposition on all three counts at once. They are governed by a separate law, they **double** the fee for third-country nationals to €726.72 *per semester* (€1,453/year), and — critically — several of them do impose the credit rule the applied-sciences law omits. **IMC Krems prints "minimum 180 ECTS lasting at least six semesters" verbatim. WU Wien requires "at least 180 ECTS with 45 ECTS in business administration."**

So the flexible §4(4) rule is **permissive, not binding** — it allows an institution to be flexible, it does not force it. Check the actual wording on each programme page rather than assuming Austria as a whole is open.

The English question — settled, and the answer is that you need the test

An earlier draft of this report suggested FH Kufstein might let you skip an English certificate via a medium-of-instruction letter. **We checked the actual wording and it will not work for you.**

Kufstein accepts such a letter only where it *"clearly demonstrates the language competence at **CEFR level B2 or higher**."* A letter from a faculty that taught you in **French and Arabic** demonstrates the opposite. The clause is real, but it is not a route for someone whose degree was not English-medium.

So: you need IELTS 6.0, TOEFL 72 or PTE 60. Duolingo is explicitly rejected. Budget for the test and book it — there is no side door here, at Kufstein or anywhere else in Austria. (Vienna accepts such letters only from EU/EEA/Swiss/UK/US/Australian/NZ/Canadian institutions, which structurally excludes Tunisia.)

One caution on fees. Austria does *not* give you a developing-country waiver. The regulation that once listed Tunisia was repealed in 2019 and the current list covers only Least Developed Countries. Aggregator sites still repeat the old list.

France — the natural fit, but the money changed

France remains your most natural destination: you are a native French speaker, the system descends from the one you studied under, and it thinks in "Bac+3" rather than credit counts.

But do not use old cost information. A decree of **19 May 2026** ended the era of near-automatic fee exemptions. Verified current rates:

	Amount
Master's, non-EU differentiated rate	**€3,950/year**
CVEC (compulsory student levy)	€105
Budget	**~€4,055/year**

Exemptions still exist but are now decided case by case on three grounds: your **personal situation, including your means**; holding a **French government scholarship**; or a reciprocity agreement. Two of those you can actively pursue — and a French government scholarship exempts you **automatically**, making it worth far more than its headline value.

*(We earlier suggested asking about a €2,633 "reduced rate". Don't bother — it turns out to be Paris 1's rate for students taking a **second** degree, which doesn't apply to you.)*

The real financial barrier in France is not the tuition

On 1 August 2026 the student-visa resource requirement rose from €615 to €877.50 per month (décret n° 2026-526), now indexed to 47% of the minimum wage and revised annually. It applies to permit **renewals** as well as the first application.

That means demonstrating roughly €14,500 for year one — about three and a half times the tuition. If France is your target, this is the number to plan your finances around, not the €3,950.

Cost of living reinforces the point. UNEF's 2025 figures for monthly student costs:

City	Per month
Rennes	**€1,192**
Nantes	~€1,212
Toulouse	~€1,215
Lille	~€1,220
Montpellier	~€1,221 (**transport free**)
Bordeaux	~€1,290
Lyon	€1,324
Paris	**€1,627**

Studying in Paris costs about **€4,800 more per year** than Rennes — more than a full year's tuition. Choose the city as deliberately as the programme.

Three French realities to plan around:

1. **Campus France comes first, and early.** The *Études en France* procedure is mandatory for Tunisian residents. It opens around **1 October 2026** and closes around **15 January 2027** — one to two months *before* the deadlines printed on the programme pages themselves. Fee 400 TND. There is a compulsory interview, and it can be done in Sousse.
2. **You are not exempt from a French language test.** We expected you would be. You are not — Tunisia's official language is Arabic, so no nationality-based exemption applies. Plan on a **TCF or DELF/DALF before October 2026**, unless a specific programme dispenses you. (You *are* exempt at ULiège in Belgium, which accepts prior education in French.)
3. **Watch the M1/M2 trap.** Many attractive French programmes only admit at M2, which assumes you already hold an M1. Entering at **M1** from a licence is what you need. This single detail matters more than a programme's reputation.

Italy — the cheapest real degree in Europe, if the paperwork goes right

Italy scales tuition to family income through the **ISEE** system, and foreign families can obtain an *ISEE parificato*.

At **Bologna, an ISEE at or below €27,000 means a contribution of zero.** Total outlay becomes about **€157 per year** — regional tax, stamp duty and insurance. That is not a typo, and it is a full state degree.

There is also a regional grant, **ER-GO, worth €7,171 per year** for students living away from home with an ISEE at or below €16,666, which adds fee exemption, accommodation and canteen access. Non-EU students are explicitly eligible. The window runs 23 June to 24 August.

The risks are administrative, not academic. Your documents must be issued by Tunisian authorities, legalised at the Italian Embassy in Tunis, and translated. The single input most likely to push your ISEE up is the **conventional valuation of your family home at €500/m²** — model that before assuming you qualify. The ISEE deadline is around 30 October; missing it costs €100 and puts you in the top band.

Tunisia is **not** on Italy's "particularly poor countries" list — that was checked against the actual decree text (DM 176 of 24 February 2026, 46 countries). The €200 flat fee does not apply to you.

The French-speaking advantage, assessed honestly

You asked whether being a native French speaker should outweigh the appeal of studying in English elsewhere. Our answer: **yes, but for employment reasons more than study reasons.**

- **Studying** in English is achievable — you need one test.
- **Working** in a marketing role in a language you do not speak fluently is much harder. Marketing is a language-heavy profession. In Ireland or the Netherlands you would compete for English-language roles against native speakers; in France, Belgium or Luxembourg you can work in French from day one.

France, Belgium and Luxembourg give you a wider pool (French- *and* English-taught), no language test in Belgium's case, and a real job-market advantage. **Belgium deserves more attention than it usually gets:** €5,369/year all-in for non-EU students at ULiège, a confirmed French-test exemption for applicants educated in French, a 12-month search year with **unrestricted** labour access, and — a gap we closed — a genuine bridging route, with ULB, UCLouvain Saint-Louis and IHECS all allowing up to 60 complementary credits, comfortably more than your 34-credit gap.

One caution on Belgium: ULiège publishes a **minimum 12/20 average**. You clear it by nothing at all.

Countries to treat carefully

Ireland is strong on cost and post-study rights — Stamp 1G runs **24 months** against the UK's 18 from January 2027. One of our researchers claimed Ireland bars marketing roles from work permits; **we checked the official list and that is wrong.** Only estate agents and conference organisers are excluded from that occupational group. Marketing roles are permit-eligible. There is even a carve-out favouring speakers of non-EEA languages in specialist digital-marketing roles — which describes you.

The UK's post-study route is 18 months for you, not two years. We confirmed the rule verbatim on gov.uk: two years only if you *apply* by 31 December 2026, 18 months from 1 January 2027. Starting in autumn 2027 and graduating in 2028–29, you get **18 months**. Any UK-versus-Ireland comparison must use 18 against Ireland's 24.

The UK is otherwise viable through roughly three institutions and no more. Fees run £16,000–30,000 almost everywhere; the exceptions are York St John (£11,800), Wrexham, and Westminster as a stretch. Northern Ireland is **not** the cheap route people assume: Queen's charges international students **£23,000** against £7,700 for locals, and Ulster **£18,310** against £7,490. Add £776/year health surcharge, a £558 visa, and £10,539 to be held for 28 days.

Germany should be deprioritised — but we now know precisely why, and it is *not* your credentials.

We managed to query **anabin**, Germany's official recognition database, directly (its public interface doesn't render, but its underlying API does). The results are unambiguous and good news:

- **Université de Sousse is rated H+** — a recognised state institution.
- **Licence Fondamentale -> "Entspricht"** — *equivalent* to a German three-year Bachelor.
- **Licence Appliquée -> "Bedingt vergleichbar"** — conditionally comparable.

Note what that means: Germany rates the *Fondamentale* HIGHER than the *Appliquée* — the exact reverse of the Dutch verdict. So there is no single answer to "which licence is better"; it depends entirely on which country you are applying to. Do not carry the Dutch logic into Germany.

What actually blocks you in Germany is the **grade and the language**. A representative case: THM's free English-taught Digital Marketing MSc requires a **2.3 minimum grade, 210 ECTS, and German B1** — three separate walls. Only private schools drop the GPA bar, at private-school prices. Add a **blocked account of €11,904** (€992/month) for the visa. Studienkolleg cannot help; it is for bachelor's entry only.

The Netherlands depends entirely on your diploma. If it says *Licence Appliquée*, Dutch applied-sciences (HBO) master's accept you directly, and the pre-master's visa problems are irrelevant because you would not need one. If it says *Licence Fondamentale*, Nuffic rates you a full year below a Dutch bachelor and the country is effectively closed.

The Nordics — two reversals since our first draft

Both of these went the opposite way to what we first reported, so read this rather than any earlier summary.

Finland has closed. A full-cost tuition law took effect on **1 August 2026**, and — visible only in Finnish — *"from spring 2026, scholarships are no longer granted to incoming fee-liable applicants."* Confirmed independently at Jyväskylä, Oulu and Uniarts. The widely repeated claim that Finnish universities waive 50–100% for non-EU students is now **false**. What survives is early-bird discounts and second-year waivers: net **€7,000–10,000/year**. Finland's applied universities remain closed to you anyway, on the two-year work-experience rule.

Norway has re-opened. Norway is repealing the cost-covering requirement after roughly an **80% collapse in international enrolment**, and eight institutions cut their 2026/27 fees. **UiA publishes NOK 63,000/year ~ €5,385** for its business master's — and Norway's year-based credential rule makes your 146 a clean pass. Norway's real obstacle is **liquidity, not cost**: you must prove **NOK 170,368 ~ €14,600** in funds, against Finland's €9,600.

Sweden is closed on funding: Tunisia is **not** among the Swedish Institute scholarship's 34 eligible countries (Egypt and Morocco are).

Denmark is the quiet strong option. Aalborg's MSc in Economics and Business Administration — with Business Data Science and Marketing & Sales tracks — costs **€7,450/year**, and about 15 fully-funded government scholarships (full tuition plus €1,503/month) are awarded by **automatic consideration**. Combined with Denmark's free, legally binding credential assessment, it is the best place in Europe to have a 146-credit question. One caution: Denmark's three-year post-study permit is **not** unrestricted work — 90 hours/month — and converting to a work permit faces a **€74,000** salary floor.

For post-study rights alone, **Finland's two-year, any-sector permit is the best in Europe** — it just costs more to get there now.

Hungary is worth exactly one application: Tunisia is a confirmed **Stipendium Hungaricum** partner for full degrees, which covers tuition and adds a stipend and accommodation allowance. The 2027/28 call opens around November 2026. Competitive — apply, don't rely.

What we could not check

Being straight about the gaps. Five of our research streams were cut short when the research session hit a hard capacity limit:

- **The Nordics** (Sweden, Denmark, Finland) were not swept for programmes. What we know comes indirectly: fees are substantial, Finland's applied universities require **two years of work experience** you do not have, and Denmark offers a free, binding credential assessment.
- **Austria and Germany have since been swept** — the findings above reflect that. Still unverified within Austria: FH St. Pölten's digital marketing master (site blocked), FH Vorarlberg's programme status, and Graz/Innsbruck/Salzburg/MODUL universities individually.
- **Scholarships** were only partially covered — see deliverable 5 for what survived.
- **Private business schools** were not systematically assessed.
- **A second pass on France** (the ~30 IAE network) did not complete, so French Directions 1 and 2 are under-sampled: about six of roughly thirty IAEs were checked.

Cost-of-living figures are missing throughout. Every researcher declined to estimate them rather than publish numbers they could not source, which was the right call but leaves a real gap.